SMB AI Readiness Checklist

The 20 questions we walk through in week one of every engagement

Taylored AI - tayloredai.com

How to use this checklist

Answer each question honestly - the goal is a clear picture, not a good score.
Weak answers are not failures; they are your roadmap. Most businesses find 2-3 areas that need work before AI will pay off.
If several items in one section are weak, that section is your priority.
Anything you cannot answer at all deserves a closer look before you spend money on AI.

1. Processes

- [ ] Do you have written steps (SOPs) for your 3 most repeated workflows?
- [ ] Could a new hire execute your core process from documentation alone?
- [ ] Do you measure how long your key workflows take?
- [ ] When something goes wrong, can you trace where it broke?

2. Data

- [ ] Is your customer/contact data in one system, or scattered?
- [ ] Do you have duplicates and inconsistencies in your records?
- [ ] Can you find any document you need in under a minute?
- [ ] Do you know which of your data is sensitive (customer, financial, legal)?

3. Governance

- [ ] Do you have written rules for how staff may use AI tools?
- [ ] Does everyone know what data must never go into an AI tool?
- [ ] Do you review AI tools for security before adopting them?
- [ ] If an AI tool caused a problem tomorrow, who would respond?

4. People

- [ ] Is your team open to new tools, or skeptical?
- [ ] Has anyone had hands-on AI training on your real work (not demos)?
- [ ] Does someone own technology decisions - even informally?
- [ ] Would your team tell you if AI tools were creating problems?

5. Focus & Budget

- [ ] Do you have 1-3 specific problems you want AI to address?
- [ ] Do you have budget, or could you free budget for the right case?
- [ ] Can you commit a few hours per week from your best process person?
- [ ] Are you ready to measure results rather than assume them?

Scoring yourself

Mostly strong answers

You are a strong candidate for automation and agentic AI. Pick your single most repetitive multi-step workflow and start there.

Mixed - some strong, some weak

An AI process audit will rank your opportunities by ROI so you sequence them with confidence. Fix foundations in weak sections first.

Mostly weak or unknown

Do not buy tools yet. Document your core workflows and set basic AI rules first - AI amplifies your processes, good or bad. Education helps your team get there faster.

Want an expert read on your answers?

Take the free AI Readiness Assessment at tayloredai.com/assessment - 12 questions, instant score, and a plain-English recommendation. Or book a free 30-minute consult and talk it through.